FORMULA 1

2026 SEASON

Technical & Sporting Regulations

A Beginner's Guide to Formula 1

Overview

The 2026 Formula 1 regulations represent the most significant overhaul in over a decade. Every major area of the car is affected: power units, aerodynamics, chassis dimensions, fuel, and the financial regulations. The goals are to improve racing, increase sustainability, reduce costs, and attract new manufacturers.

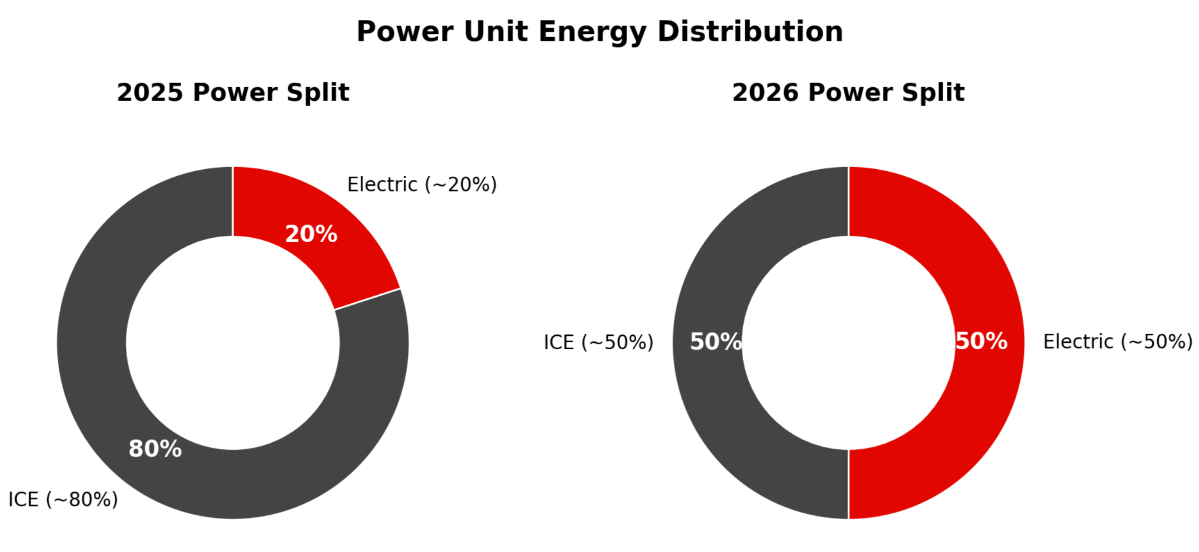
350	768	100%	$215M
kW MGU-K	kg Min Weight	Sustainable	Budget Cap

Why 2026?

The current Concorde Agreement, power unit regulations, and aerodynamic rules all converge for a reset in 2026. This alignment created a natural opportunity for a comprehensive regulation change and attracted new entrants like Audi and Cadillac/GM.

Power Unit Overhaul

The 2026 power unit is a radical departure from the current design. The electrical component of the powertrain is dramatically increased, targeting a roughly 50/50 split between electric and combustion power.



Power unit energy split: 2025 vs 2026

Key Changes

- MGU-H (Motor Generator Unit - Heat) is eliminated entirely, simplifying the power unit and reducing costs
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MGU-K output increases from 120 kW to 350 kW (nearly triple), making electric power roughly equal to ICE output

- Battery (Energy Store) capacity significantly increased to support the higher MGU-K output
- Internal combustion engine (ICE) output decreases to approximately 400 kW, down from ~550 kW
- Total system output remains similar to current cars (~750 kW / ~1,000 bhp), but the power delivery changes dramatically
- Engine RPM limit remains at 15,000 but expected operating range may shift with the new power balance

Power Unit Suppliers

Supplier	Teams Supplied	Status
Ferrari	Ferrari, Haas, Cadillac	Incumbent
Mercedes	Mercedes, McLaren, Alpine, Williams	Incumbent
Honda RBPT	Red Bull Racing, Racing Bulls, Aston Martin	Incumbent
Audi	Sauber/Audi	New entrant

Why Remove the MGU-H?

The MGU-H was the most complex and expensive component of the current power unit, creating a barrier for new manufacturers. Its removal lowers costs, simplifies the architecture, and was a key condition for Audi's entry and GM/Cadillac's future engine plans.

Sustainable Fuels

For the first time, Formula 1 mandates 100% advanced sustainable fuel. This is a cornerstone of the sport's commitment to reaching net-zero carbon by 2030.

- Fuel must be 100% sustainable (non-fossil origin)
- Can be produced from municipal waste, agricultural waste, or captured carbon combined with green hydrogen (e-fuels)
- Must be a 'drop-in' fuel compatible with standard fuel infrastructure and similar energy density to current fuels
- Fuel flow rate adjusted to account for the shift in power balance toward electric energy
- All fuel suppliers must meet FIA sustainability certification standards

Real-World Impact

F1's sustainable fuel development is intended to accelerate technology that can eventually be used in road cars and other transportation. The goal is to prove that high-performance sustainable fuels are viable at the highest level of motorsport.

Active Aerodynamics

The 2026 cars introduce active aerodynamics as a replacement for the Drag Reduction System (DRS). Instead of a simple rear wing flap, both the front and rear wings can change their configuration in real time.

How It Works

- Both front and rear wing elements are adjustable, changing angle and configuration during the lap
- X-Mode (low drag): Wing elements open/flatten on straights to minimize drag and maximize top speed
- Z-Mode (high downforce): Wings in maximum downforce configuration for cornering and braking zones
- Unlike DRS, active aero is available to all cars, not just those within 1 second of the car ahead
- The system operates automatically based on speed, throttle position, and track zones, with some driver input

DRS vs. Active Aero Comparison

Feature	DRS (2011-2025)	Active Aero (2026+)
Wings affected	Rear only	Front and rear
Activation	Within 1s of car ahead	Available to all cars
Detection zones	Specific DRS zones	Speed/zone-based
Modes	Open / Closed	Multiple configurations
Driver control	Manual button	Automatic + driver input
Purpose	Reduce rear drag for overtaking	Full drag/downforce management

Overtaking Impact

The FIA projects that active aero, combined with reduced dirty air from the new regulations, will maintain or improve overtaking opportunities compared to DRS. The variable wing configurations add a new tactical dimension to racing.

Car Design Changes

The 2026 cars are significantly smaller, lighter, and designed to produce less disruptive wake for following cars.

Dimensions & Weight

- Minimum weight: 768 kg (down from 798 kg, a 30 kg reduction)
- Wheelbase: 200 mm shorter than current cars
- Overall width: 100 mm narrower
- Cars will be visually more compact and agile-looking
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Weight reduction achieved despite the larger, heavier battery

Floor & Downforce

- Venturi tunnels (the shaped floor channels used since 2022) are eliminated
- Replaced by a flat floor with a larger rear diffuser
- Ground effect downforce is still the primary source of grip, but generated differently
- The goal is to reduce the sensitivity of downforce to ride height and reduce porpoising
- Front wing is simpler with fewer elements, working with active aero system
- Rear wing designed around the active aero mechanism

Crash Structures & Safety

- Updated front and side impact structures
- Halo remains mandatory with updated integration requirements
- New rear impact structure specifications
- Roll hoop design updated following recent incidents
- Survival cell testing requirements increased

2025 vs. 2026 Comparison

A side-by-side look at the key differences between the outgoing 2025 and incoming 2026 regulations.

Category	2025 Regulations	2026 Regulations
MGU-H	Yes (120 kW harvest)	Eliminated
MGU-K Output	120 kW	350 kW
ICE Output	~550 kW	~400 kW
Total Power	~750 kW	~750 kW (different split)
Electric Share	~20%	~50%
Fuel	10% sustainable blend	100% sustainable
Rear Wing	DRS (passive)	Active aero (multi-mode)
Front Wing	Fixed	Active aero
Floor	Venturi tunnels	Flat floor + diffuser
Min. Weight	798 kg	768 kg
Width	2000 mm	1900 mm
Wheelbase	~3,600 mm (typical)	~3,400 mm
Budget Cap	~$140M	$215M (expanded scope)

Category	2025 Regulations	2026 Regulations
Teams	10	11 (Cadillac joins)
PU Suppliers	4 (Ferrari, Merc, Honda, Renault)	4 (Ferrari, Merc, Honda, Audi)

Budget Cap Changes

The cost cap headline figure rises from approximately $140 million to $215 million, but this increase is largely due to expanding what is included rather than allowing more spending.

- Headline cap: $215 million (up from ~$140M)
- More items now fall under the cap, including previously excluded costs like power unit development allocations and marketing
- Power unit cost cap introduced separately to control engine development spending
- Sprint event bonuses and prize money adjustments factored in
- Penalty structure remains: minor overages (< 5%) result in fines and reduced wind tunnel time; major overages can result in points deductions or exclusion
- New team exemptions: Cadillac receives a temporary uplift in their first seasons to account for startup costs

> **Why the Increase?**
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> The headline number looks much higher, but the real-terms spending limit has not increased dramatically. The broader scope brings more team spending under scrutiny, which should improve competitive balance and financial fairness across the grid.

Sporting Regulation Updates

Grid Expansion

With 11 teams and 22 drivers, qualifying knockout thresholds are adjusted: Q1 eliminates 5 drivers (positions 18-22), Q2 eliminates 5 more (positions 13-17), and Q3 features the top 12 drivers.

Sprint Format

The Sprint format continues with 6 events in 2026. Points remain 8-7-6-5-4-3-2-1 for the top 8 finishers. No fastest lap bonus in Sprints.

Power Unit Allocation

Each driver is allowed a specific number of power unit components across the season before incurring grid penalties. With the simpler PU design (no MGU-H), allocation numbers are adjusted for 2026.

Testing & Development

- Pre-season testing expanded to three sessions (Barcelona + 2x Bahrain)
- In-season testing days slightly increased for the first year of new regulations
- Wind tunnel and CFD allocations continue to be based on inverse championship position (lower-placed teams get more development time)
- Aero testing period (ATR) reset for all teams at the start of 2026

The Big Picture

The 2026 regulations represent F1's vision for the future: cars that are lighter, more electric, powered by sustainable fuels, and designed to produce better racing. The elimination of the MGU-H and introduction of active aerodynamics are the two most visible changes, while the sustainable fuel mandate positions F1 as a leader in motorsport sustainability.

For fans, the key impacts will be different-sounding cars (more electric whine, less turbocharged whoosh), new overtaking dynamics with active aero replacing DRS, and a larger, more diverse grid with new manufacturers and teams.